workers. In Odisha, during its elections last year, Modi told a rally that the missing keys to the Jagannath temple's treasury had "gone to Tamil Nadu". This was a veiled reference to a Tamil bureaucrat considered close to the then ruling party. In Uttar Pradesh during the Lok Sabha poll last year, the prime minister said the southern allies of the Congress insulted *sanatana dharma*.

The DMK has reacted forcefully to each of these accusations. Chief minister M.K. Stalin has even asked if Modi has the "guts" to say the same thing in Tamil Nadu. Observers also note how the tone of his references to Tamil Nadu change depending on whether he's addressing audiences elsewhere or tailoring them to Tamil voters. Outside, they inevitably play on local pride and regional suspicions, says an observer. "It's clear enough. Tamil Nadu serves as a punching bag if it helps consolidate votes in other states," he says.

Stalin, meanwhile, frames his counter within an idea of "respect for federal unity". This also syncs well with the needs of larger Opposition unity, he points out. There's now a force that affects all states, a common cause that bands them together rather than splitting them apart: the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. In August, Stalin had visited Bihar to take part in the INDIA rally, where he was vocal against the SIR exercise in Bihar. That's a suitably federal-minded solution to a strategy that, as a senior DMK leader puts it, relies on "polarising voters by turning linguistic and regional diversity into electoral fault lines".

The BJP rebalances this within Tamil Nadu. Here, the party's tone is markedly different. Tamil language, heritage and pride are invoked repeatedly; the PM quotes Tamil poets and praises the state's contribution to national culture. Outside, it becomes a troubling 'other'. The Dravidian bugbear—distant, defiant, culturally alien.

This duality perhaps holds down the BJP's southern experiment. In their defence, Tamil Nadu BJP leaders argue the PM's comments are aimed at the DMK, not the state or its people. Yet the question remains: can caricaturing Tamil Nadu outside, as a charged rhetorical weapon, ever sit well with attempts to win them over within? ■

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NATIVIST LINE
Modi at a rally in Saharsa, Bihar

Takeaways

- **In a poll speech, PM said TN mistreats Bihari migrants; he has ribbed TN in Odisha, UP too**
- **Stalin takes umbrage, dares Modi to say it while in TN; being used as a punching bag: DMK**

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By **Avaneesh Mishra**

WHEN ALL THE BIG NAMES ASSEMBLED in Ayodhya on Diwali-eve last month for the grand Deepotsav celebrations, the spotlight fell not on the ghats illuminated with over 2.6 million diyas, but on two empty chairs—figuratively speaking. Deputy chief ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak were conspicuously missing. The episode, which made public a long-speculated schism in the upper echelons of the Yogi Adityanath government, has catalysed debate over its future shape.

Their absence, insiders admit, was no coincidence. Both had reportedly cancelled their visit at the last moment after noticing their names missing from the official advertisements; they had not even been assigned a